

“Problems can be met by delegation of power”

ASHOK CHAVAN

CHIEF MINISTER, MAHARASHTRA

The discussion for the autonomy of states has to be seen in the context of our Constitution. We have a federal structure in which there are three functional areas, an exclusive area of the Centre, an exclusive area of the state and a common and concurrent area in which both the state and the Centre operate simultaneously. The scheme of Constitution is to provide for a strong Centre to protect the unity and the integrity of the country. The framers of our Constitution made an elaborate distribution of government powers—legislative, administrative and financial—between

the Union and the states. To make it strong, they gave weightage to the Union, allocating it dominant and relatively larger powers, for example like the defence forces, atomic energy, war and peace, citizenship, railways, posts and telegraph etc. The states have been provided exclusive jurisdiction in matters pertaining to public health, sanitation, local self-governance, police, etc. Finally, the Concurrent List includes subjects like criminal laws, the Indian Penal Code, the Code of Criminal Procedure, trade, commerce and others.

The Constitution is not a static frame, but an organic living institution. The Centre should introduce rewards linked to performance against specific parameters. A large number of Central-sponsored schemes have been introduced by the Government such as the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, National Rural Health Mission, to name just two. So while such schemes are welcome and have benefited the states immensely, there is a need to make these schemes flexible so that states can tailor them to suit their own conditions. It is felt that more autonomy should be given to the states to develop badly neglected infrastructure by taking decisions on their own.

I would like to conclude by supporting the stronger and greater role provided to our Union by the Constitution, at the same time the difficulties experienced by the states in implementation of developmental activity which must be resolved through delegation of powers.

REUBEN SINGH



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DISCUSSION

Q. Do you think that strong states mean a stronger India?

Chouhan: My point is that all states should be treated equally; no state should get extra privileges.

Q. How can you make consultations between the Centre and states more meaningful?

Abdullah: My complaint is that opinions that we present are judged on the basis whether you are pro-Centre or anti-Centre. We don't want a situation where it becomes necessary for state governments to cozy up with the Centre for

what should actually be their natural share.

Q. Why is Raj Thackeray targeting North Indians and getting away with it?

Chavan: Well, there is no special status that he enjoys within the country. I want to clearly state that we do not support his party's campaign, this discrimination between Maharashtrians and North Indians. He often raises this issue during the election season.

Q. You are all partners in some coalition or the other, so

why don't you talk and get the autonomy thing sorted out?

Chavan: Coalition and autonomy are two different issues and I don't think they are related to each other. All states desire autonomy focused on what areas we want autonomy and the focus is on financial issues from the government of India. I have no complaints because we are working in the present position under a coalition like we are with the NCP in Maharashtra, but I would appeal to the people of India to vote for a single party whosoever

they desire. I feel in a country like India, we should have a single-party government coming to power.

Q. Do you agree with this?

Chouhan: It is not about parties or coalition; there are some issues on which we feel that state should be supported. And for this there should be discussions among chief ministers and experts. We should think beyond a political perspective even if it is our government at the Centre. The states should be supported to fulfil their own expectations and hopes of the people.